TASK 4: SEVERITY & CASE CLASSIFICATION

PHARMACOVIGILANCE — ADVERSE DRUG REACTION CASE REVIEW

Objective

To classify the adverse drug reactions (ADRs) in the task according to severity, seriousness, and expectedness, and explain the reason for each classification.

Key definitions

Term	Simple explanation
Severity	How intense or bad the reaction is: mild, moderate, or severe.
Seriousness	Whether the reaction meets a regulatory seriousness criterion, such as death, a life-threatening event, hospitalisation/prolonged hospitalisation, significant disability, congenital anomaly, or another medically important event.
Expectedness	Whether the reaction is described in the applicable approved product information/reference safety information.

Case classification table

Case	Drug & adverse reaction	Severity	Seriousness	Expectedness
01	Amoxicillin — skin rash and itching	Mild to moderate, depending on extent and symptoms	Generally non-serious if there are no serious complications or qualifying outcomes	Check the applicable product information; expected if listed
02	Ibuprofen — gastrointestinal bleeding requiring hospitalisation	Severe	Serious — hospitalisation is reported	Check the applicable product information; expected if listed
03	Metformin — lactic acidosis	Severe / potentially life-threatening	Serious — medically important and potentially life-threatening; use the case details to confirm criteria	Check the applicable product information; expected if listed

Important: Expectedness cannot be confirmed from the drug name alone. Compare each reaction with the exact approved product label/reference safety information specified by the trainer or task.

Case-wise explanation

Case 01 — Amoxicillin: skin rash and itching

A limited rash with itching may be mild or moderate. If the case does not involve hospitalisation, a life-threatening condition, significant disability, or another medically important outcome, it is generally classified as non-serious. Severity depends on how extensive and intense the rash is. If symptoms suggest anaphylaxis or another serious allergic reaction, reassess the case.

Case 02 — Ibuprofen: gastrointestinal bleeding requiring hospitalisation

This case is serious because hospitalisation is explicitly stated. The reaction is severe because gastrointestinal bleeding can cause significant blood loss and may require urgent treatment. Expectedness must be checked against the applicable ibuprofen safety information.

Case 03 — Metformin: lactic acidosis

Lactic acidosis is a severe and potentially life-threatening condition. It should be treated as a serious, medically important event; documented life-threatening status or hospitalisation would further support seriousness. Expectedness must be checked against the applicable metformin safety information.

Summary and conclusion

Case 01: provisionally non-serious and mild-to-moderate. Case 02: serious due to hospitalisation and severe in intensity. Case 03: severe and medically important/potentially life-threatening, so it should be assessed as serious. Severity, seriousness, and expectedness are different concepts and must be assessed separately. Final expectedness decisions should be based on the approved reference safety information and the complete case details.

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